

And Still I Breathe

A sequence of poems by
Rik Roots

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Dedicated to the Fun and Joy
of Poetry

Table of Contents

[Tumblewords](#)

» *It's like a boil, this need to write*

[Poverty](#)

» *I want to write of iced desolations*

[A tribute, of sorts](#)

» *Snow on the bough snuggles about*

[March Tease](#)

» *This year the world around*

[The Cake](#)

» *Simmel, it breaks our Lenten fast*

[Rapture v2](#)

» *One day I woke and the world was stacked*

[Twenty Twenty](#)

» *I have a chip that lets me palm*

[When the net goes down](#)

» *Blue sky at noon: deep, smooth, no clutter*

[Annie](#)

» *Annie sees dragons in all things*

[Not a Good Fit](#)

» *Our cozy office echoes more today*

[You'll Never Guess What](#)

» *I watch his mouth, let the slip of his lips*

[Rita](#)

» *We gather like clotting scrapes, a clutter*

Attic

» *It takes more than a ladder*

Today we count in perfections

» *My first wart grew where my fingers would cross*

Magpies

» *It's the way they eye you*

Rush Hour

» *A surl of girls at bicker, their satchels*

Flotsam

» *A parade of waves renders pale fat, salty*

Exercising my Right

» *I voted for sausage, once, at a winter*

Poppy

» *They say: we must remember!*

Three strophes to change your life forever!

» *Shall I lie to you, today*

Who?

» *My book has moved again, the edge of pens*

And Still I Breathe

» *The sky ripened and the sun bled*

Tumblewords

It's like a boil, this need to write –
a pulsed heat set at the back of my skull
that compels phrases to form and dance

in patterns: cadenced hopes, a catenate
of murmurs at the threshold of meaning
beyond their means; blastocyte verses –

I shall lance that urge now, watch words
spurt too soon from the pock-wound, reach
ears before their time – oh, sweet relief!

Poverty

I want to write of iced desolations –
my skull-bound voice would rather sing.

I could pretend the wind outside is shrill –
it barely stirs a leaf. What chance have I

of etching stark horizons when my eyes
fill with the scrabbles of kids on bikes?

Such first-world problems I must suffer, stuck
here in this wealth of health and simple hopes:

a sturdy roof, refrigeration, heat that burps
through pipes – I have a tap that drips

and cash to pay a man to fix it. Still,
there's always the internets to steep my gut

in growly biles, bring acid foams to churn –
a proxy grief to make some words spill out.

A tribute, of sorts

(After: 11 February 2012)

Snow on the bough snuggles about
the form of a blackbird, her brown feathers
still, now, her hymn stolen by the gale
buffeting the twigs that built her cage.

So cold, this weather. A chorus of beaks
unite, for a moment, to mark the end
of a heart-rent song sent to the heavens
too soon, too soon. A snowdrop blooms.

March Tease

This year the world around
seems earlier, some weeks
ahead of the earth's curve,

keen to get things done –
buds unpacked, petals stretched
and shaken dry in a cool

of meandered air – as if
it knows the hidden plan:
interesting times shall come.

The Cake

Simnel, it breaks our Lenten fast
in halves, she says, her glasses perched
mid-nose, dusted in flour. A treat
we make for Mothers day, all fruits
and zests, sugars and spices mixed
in the last of the flour we sieved for weevils,
and eggs and butter churned before sunrise –
now spit in the bowl, my lad, to keep
the fair folks away: them buggers would sour
most all of our work. See how it sticks
to the spoon? Now bring us the rounded tin,
then roll out that almond paste as flat
as the cat your dad ran over last week
and cut it in circles: two we need.
Then we can pour, half over half
with the ladies' fancy between the pair –
though it melts in the bake, golden no more.
Once that is done we top it in marchpane
and toast the whole in flames to sear
the tastes together. And last, we sprinkle
garlands and buds to make it a treat:
some petals of apple, some snowdrop hope
and a twist of purple lobelia, just here,
for betrayal.

Rapture v2

One day I woke and the world was stacked
in a new placenta, a box that cuddled my palm
like comforts. "I shall be your new friend,"
it didn't say, for no tool talks platitudes.

Before I would check for my face in clouds:
now I have many faces there. Some smile.

What moves beyond my thumb-summoned truth
is false news; I switch past ghosts, eat
amid revenants. Between emojis stir bears
from cracks.

Twenty Twenty

I have a chip that lets me palm
my way through gates and barriers
unhindered; journeys happen. Cars
appear at fingersnap, their calm

dispatch a pleasure bought online
unseen, but checkable by app –
a happy state, this wiretap.

My shopping list emits its whine

and groceries appear, their health
and mine an algorithm's dance
towards a peak perfection. Chance
is banished here, this land where wealth

is guaranteed alongside God –
for God is in the cloud today
as is my right to sleep and play
and trade my pleasures freely: slot

me in for more celebrity –
such gossip feeds me well and keeps
the worry-mongers safe asleep
inside my skull. They must not see

such deviance, those spies and eyes
that track my worth and map my steps
– ten thousand more to win that prize!
I must not break the rhyme – objects

unwilling to comply shall be
assaulted, mocked and shamed. Each day
the same: the bus the work the play
the sex the words my thoughts ...

When the net goes down

Blue sky at noon: deep, smooth, no clutter
of cloud to stall the fall of filtered sun –
an accountant kicks her shoes from her heels,
pivots tired eyes from her frozen screen

to dream: pillow dens for her childcared boy.
Around her the chatter gathers, a growl
of irritations – deadlines missed, reports
lost: each spendthrift second sours the holy

Profit. The man who nests at the desk opposite
offers a smile, an introduction of sorts.
She would stall his words but etiquette requires
an answer from her: a name; a sympathy nod

as he lists the wrongs heaped in his in-tray.
She knows he cannot hear her words nor spy
the child inside her eyes who fights dragons
with cushions and battens and hope.

Annie

Annie sees dragons in all things
hidden like moths amid fur:
here in the bricks of her office
is a wyrm set to watch her flinch
through doors opened by ghosts.

She ignores the nip of its breath
and clips through the marbled foyer,
lets the lift-drake enfold her
in glittery wings and huff
her aloft to her work nook.

The wyvern at the tea point
winks as it casts a sear
of flame over water; she strokes
the nub of its snout as it drips
steam through her bitter grinds.

Associates walk the corridors
ahead of her, their heels a hiss
of static on the knots of a great
blue tongue, each step a whisper –
"I taste you; I hunger; I want."

Annie would tell her colleagues
she sees dragons in all things,
that the office will eat them
... but the scales on their eyes
are part of the hide, best left.

Not a Good Fit

Our cozy office echoes more today.

Where once a colleague sat, a colder light;
a clear expanse of of boxy white, contrite
desk: how could he fail? The deft display
of his dismissal scares me: bait and switch
and – gone. Just yesterday we spoke of hopes
and holidays, some action points – those ropes
that keep us dancing at our stations ... which

of us is next? I look around at friends,
acquaintances, their jaws slack and their skins
a touch more blanched. For each of us has sins,
I guess; each one of us must guard our plans
and hope the folks who file the axe forgive
our daily, thoughtless faults: I can't give in!

You'll Never Guess What

I watch his mouth, let the slip of his lips
and the sounds of his words slide slowly
out of sync. These phrases must be important:
the way he tubes his cheeks round '*boot*'
and '*threw*' suggests I should share in his shock.
"She never," I offer, keen to see if the drawl
of his vowels can twang the tether of slaver
caught at the edge of his gob. The spit
of '*she'll never change*' spats in my eyes. Still
the story spills past the paired, pink leeches
nestled within his stubbled skin – some chant
of names, some known to me. The bloodworms
stretch thin; slacken to plump comforts; part
for a moment as his tongue glides forwards
to lick them to a shine. When his teeth nova
I, too, laugh at what I hope is the joke.

Rita

We gather like clotting scrapes, a clutter
of people drawn to her door. "It needs
to be managed; she has no one, no friends
to help her sort herself." I'm late
to the crowd, rogue starling, tumbling
after the flock. "She thought the world

of him," my neighbour says. "Her world
was nailed to his; look at the clutter
in this garden!" Amid the tumbling
frames a crocus unfurls, the needs
of its cycle pushed by a threat of late
frost. Gust-whipped, it seeks friends

... I suppose at a push you can call them friends:
early bees sipping through the world
one sugar pot at a time. "Her late
husband?" I ask. He nods, the clutter
of chatter now growing louder: who needs
to do what, and how, and when. Tumbling

overhead is a skirl of clouds, tumbling
like lambs let loose in the field, friends
on the lam from the afternoon sun. "She needs
some spring smiles to thaw her world,"
he decides. Welters of lines clutter
his face. Glancing about, I can relate

to his want – I know I saw her late
last year, a cambered matron tumbling
from the pavement's cracked kerb to clutter
up the road with her shopping. We were frail friends;
she refused my help, scared that the world
would scoff at her trivial widow's needs.

"Don't fret for me. It's my son who needs
the help," she told me. "He's always late,
but it's not his fault, poor lad! The world
won't give him a breath or a break, tumbling
him between chaos and crisis – his friends
don't help; he can do without my clutter!"

Our story is clutter, like hers; boxed needs
biding to be sorted by friends come too late:
you're tumbling too fast from my world.

Attic

It takes more than a ladder
to reach the cocoon that sits
atop the bricks of her life.
"Careful! Don't fall on the dog!"

She panics too much: we are
not here to steal her history.
Rather we pack it and force it
through the wood-rimmed hole –
the suitcase that carried
her life-goods to England;
the suit she married; coats
still in their wrap, bought
on a payday whim. "He knows,"

she tells us, "he doesn't like
change." The guard he left behind
to keep her – a moment's purchase
a week before his last breath –
watches us strain-sweat-shove
the last vacuum-sucked packet
out of sight. "Grrr," I throat
back at her tongue-lolled yaps:
she smacks her cable-thick tail
on the carpet like a dare.

Today we count in perfections

One for a wish, two for a kiss ...

My first wart grew where my fingers would cross,
tight in the web; a new knuckle quick to fist
for battle. Friends asked: "who was the witch?"
We spied on playtime supervisors for evidence
of brooms, checked teacher's pockets for toads.

Three for a letter, four for something better ...

I grew a style, once, to block out the world
from my eye. I would wake early to admire
the gathering puss that pressed out the lid
and patch my face with a pirate's jewel. "Who
was the witch," asked friends. "Give us your rum!"

Five for silver, six for gold ...

I saved my impetigo for adulthood, and spread
it wide across my jaw with each fresh shave.
A mate said: "why have you been looking
under toilet doors?" Idiot: that's cold sores
and the boon of this rash is I can sprinkle it dry.

Seven for a secret never to be told ...

Do I regret those drunken lusts? Yes
– and yet: no.

Magpies

It's the way they eye you,
those two-tone bloods
perched in their manor
tree, or dance-formation
spread across the field.

You have it, and they
want it, know, head
cocked, jet-eye wide
and unblinked – and what
they want, they get.

You can't nursery rhyme
these feathers; the asbo
can only handle seven
– secrets never told –
I count eight, ten, twelve.

*We like the cut of you,
and your suit.* They caw
some chuckles as you cross
the road: *we'll check
your window later, mate!*

Rush Hour

A surl of girls at bicker, their satchels
hung low. Each lecturing voice lessens
the pleasure of the ride, rude platitudes
shilling for audience: *she was the one*
wot said it first and *she's free with her kisses*
when it suits her needs. Their stop can't come
quick enough: the sigh that slices the aisle
when they debark is plush – a prayer that spreads
the length of the bus. Their exit leaves seats
for the claim; passengers tango speechlessly,
compete for a prize – a space to plonk
our still-waking flesh as the wheels
of the Machine tumble us to work.

Flotsam

(After: 2 September 2015)

A parade of waves renders pale fat, salty
spatulas to paddle and turn his form as
the sun heats and bleaches skin. A round

of gut-trapped gas crushes a fish caught
in the folds of his cotton shirt. Nails,
mother-trimmed, pearl and soften as

jelly combs tangle his hair; soon they wear
grit as he beaches, a message in red
that spells in angled limbs: enough!

Exercising my Right

I voted for sausage, once, at a winter
barbecue, but the drumsticks won and I
went hungry. Again. *"Why do you insist*

on being different?" Who knows? I don't
plan it. But whenever the chance comes
for me to raise a hand, a finger, a pencil
somehow I put the big cross right where

the treasure ain't buried. Like that bloke
who surveyed Tenerife for an airport, put
his X in the north to show the only spot
on the island fatal to planes and then died
before he could tell others. Boom, they went,
those sturdy tin birds and there we had it:
the best part of a thousand body bags
over the years. So call me Cassandra

and see if I care – I'll always vote for facts,
not faces or charm, because I can see
the fat chancers at forty paces and I can tell
the Edens they sell are as honest and useful
as a sack of Canarian fog and even though

I know my side will lose still I will vote, not
only because of the millions who fought
for the right to top their kings as they saw fit
but also in the hope that one happy day
I'll eat barbecued sausage in the snow.

Poppy

They say: we must remember!

And while I do understand

Dulce et decorum est pro

patria mori it's the rest

of the lines that squeeze

my eyes to pain. So then,

should I wear you, little

tatter of red card stuck

on your bendy green stick

for the next week or so?

Because you mean more than

horror today, pretty flower.

This button is a token.

It says: I belong; I am

proud of my patria. It says:

we are British, great among

nations, better than lesser

types – undefeated warriors

stand tall and free; obey

our leaders, who know best.

You say: to refuse my flag
is to shit in the skulls
of people who died to keep
you safe – but those people
bled from shrapnels, gases
and fevers while generals
shot pheasant. I say: no.
This land is not that land;
my will not yours to command:
I mourn for England today.

Three strophes to change your life forever!

Shall I lie to you, today,
as I lied so many times
ago? I am good, I am fine;
the crease on my brow is age,
not rage: an applied beauty –

and yet I fret. I read memes,
each clause a spell to hope
and wealth – so many friends
to gather and garnish as I whip
our lives to blessed visions –

I am not good. There's bones
in my dreams, in my daylight
eyes: each breath is a death
to scheme and plan – no will or
time: my stage addles in worms.

Who?

My book has moved again, the edge of pens
I placed around it undisturbed, its leaves
flicked by some hand or gust just as I glanced
away – who tricks a mind this way? That page
of silent faces drew a scene from me
in some elsewhere, a second's glimpse, no more,
and what was there before me shifted. Ghosts?

My room seems stable – walls and carpets all
in place, their weaves and paints remembered right.
The window blind is up, and still; the road
outside seems bright and warm, its cars a chain
of chromes and dents and rusts. Pedestrians
ignore my unblinked stare. The clock says five –
it should be half gone three ... my time has moved

again! The man who comes to wipe my sores
is back today, his whistled tune a grace
of noise to take the ticks of lying clocks
from ears that used to work. I used to work.
This flesh is not my flesh; this skin I wear
is nothing more than wrinkled sunshine. Who
took that old book of grinning lives from me?

And Still I Breathe

The sky ripened and the sun bled;
a shoal of clouds scaled like salmon
in their beaked rush to spawn. Why
does looking up empty my lungs?
Tomorrow the earth's turn will be
as surreal as every other sky-sketch
and my eyes wide like I'm two again.